ODISHA: BJP'S TRIBAL TRUMP CARD PG 9

UPFRONT

ANDHRA PRADESH: NAIDU 4.0 PG 10



FIGHTING FOR THE FUTURE Student union members protest outside the education ministry, Jun. 10

ARUN KUMAR

MEDICAL ENTRANCE EXAMS

A NEET SUBVERSION

By Shelly Anand

June 4, results, and a bit of snafu. No, this isn't about the general election—those descriptors applied to another realm, an equally national one. The same evening when all eyes were on the Lok Sabha results, nearly a quarter of a million families across India were holding their breath for another kind of disclosure about their future. The National Testing Agency (NTA), acting about 10 days ahead of schedule, was putting out the results of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test—Undergraduate (NEET-UG) 2024, conducted on May 5. A single door to all the medical courses and allied pursuits at the under-graduate level in India, it had some 2.4 million aspirants standing outside it expectantly. But no sooner had it started revolving, a Pandora's box of questions and doubts opened up.

As many as 67 students scored 720 out of 720—a curious boom in merit, considering only two students had managed the feat in 2023. Six of these were from the same centre in Jhajjar, Haryana. More anomalies cropped up: several near-perfect scores of 718 and